



GENDER AGENDA: (above) Saigal at the Delhi Gymkhana, (right) Sardesai at the Bombay Gymkhana

authored the voluminous *Elite Clubs of India* last year. "Women are surging ahead in every field. Clubs seem to have woken up to this reality." But not without a fight. Take the 132-year-old Bombay Gymkhana. It's still reeling under the impact of the 2003 'revolution' where women fought tooth and nail to win voting rights and contest elections. The club now punctiliously celebrates every International Women's Day and sometimes male members can attend only if accompanied by women. "Today, women have the right to vote, to stand for elections to the managing committee and to recommend their children for membership—same as their male counterparts," says Censor Board member and former head of sociology at St Xavier's College, Nandini Sardesai. Not surprisingly, a "chairman" is a "chairperson" now, an address is made to both "gentlemen and ladies" and memberships are passed on to children from "parents", not "fathers".

Women are chipping away at liberation. Take Roy, for instance. Perpetually-active and infectious-high-spirited, she has her hands full, as the head of a cultural foundation, a film production company, an art gallery and a theatre unit—all under the banner of Spandan. Despite her busy schedule, she has been working very hard at the Saturday Club for the last six years. Not because she wanted glory, but because the club has been



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"another home" to her. She remembers munching on triple-deck club sandwiches as a school girl on chance Saturdays, jiving on its sprung timber floors till wee hours as a 20-something. Her election, she believes, is a sign of changing mindsets: "People simply want the club to be in competent hands—men or women."

But breaking through the male defences is never easy. "With a hotel background, I should have got main tenance and chambers but they put me in charge of the card rooms," says Kamath, managing director of facility management firm, Carewel. Also, she was plagued by a feeling of being "watched" all the time. She, however, found an important ally in her board-

room battles: a fellow committee member she married later.

"The only room we have exclusively for men now is their washroom," chuckles Saigal, who has single-handedly changed the atmosphere of the bar at the Delhi Gymkhana. She virtually parked herself at the club to make the members' favourite watering hole spiffier. "There's no one quite like Shobi," reads the June issue of the club newsletter, *Club Life*. But for Saigal—who grew up playing around the club pool, got married at the club's Rose Garden and has precious memories of sun-drenched hours spent with grandparents, parents, husband and children at the club—this is the least she could do. "This is home ground," she

says, "I get an amazing comfort level and sense of security here."

That is exactly what prompted male members all across the country to try and preserve the status quo. But now it seems to be a losing battle, and not a day too soon. At the traditional New Year's Day celebrations at the Calcutta Club this year, the president raised a toast: "We are ready to shed some of our old baggage not befitting the future." On the dance floor, Gary Lawyer's version of "The times they are a'changing," added appropriate accompaniment. It also sounded a dirge for the last remnant of the Raj in India.

with Kimi Dangor and
Akhila Krishnamurthy